



Victory lap: Aslam Inamdar, captain of the victorious Puneri Paltan, receives the PKL trophy from Vinod Tiwari (International Kabaddi Federation President) in the presence of Kailash Kanpal (CEO, Puneri Paltan) and Pullela Gopichand. PKL MEDIA

We've seen this become more broad-based. We've not discovered a diamond in the rough. We've just given them a chance to find good coaches who are open to talent irrespective of region."

Player development has come alongside better monetary conditions for those in the mix.

"Because of us, I believe that the recruitment of kabaddi players to the services to public sector undertakings has been rehabbed. Multiple other kabaddi tournaments have emerged as a result of the larger pull of Pro Kabaddi. In order to make the game aspirational, player salaries (via auction primarily) have increased from ₹12.8 lakh in the first season (top player price) to ₹2.6 crore this season. These are not random

increases; it has been slow and incremental, growing with the league slowly," he adds.

Heading the high table

Beyond the national ecosystem, Pro Kabaddi is the biggest and most successful effort in trying to take the sport to the world. The league is in itself aspirational, as evidenced by growing European interest both in viewing and player participation. E. Prasad Rao, the technical director of the league and a man who has spread the gospel of kabaddi